Throughout the gathering, it was clear that Honecker had the wind at his back. Wearing a natty grey suit and striped tie, he told delegates that the occasion confirmed the turn from ‘Cold War’ to détente in Europe: ‘Peace and security are deeply in harmony with the character of the socialist order of society.’ However, he noted ‘with concern’, that the gathering was not the final point but a prelude to new initiatives. ‘It is our objective to banish aggression and war forever from the lives of Europe’s peoples and States. Military detente was falling short of progressing political détente.’4

Honecker rejoiced when the French alphabetical seating arrangements provided his desired encounter with Gerald Ford during a dinner given by Finland’s president, Urho Kekkonen. In his golden recollections, Honecker proudly recounted congratulating Ford on the results of the Apollo-Soyuz mission, ‘He replied with congratulations on the successes of the GDR swimmers at the world championships.’ However, despite the pleasantries, archives reveal that both Ford and Chancellor Schmidt privately complained about the ‘unfortunate seating arrangements’.

President Ford remarked that he spent virtually all his time talking to Erich Honecker and Archbishop Makarios. Chancellor Schmidt also complained about his delegation being seated next to the GDR which left him no choice but to converse with Mr Honecker. Secretary Kissinger commented that the long talk Makarios had with the President was ironic inasmuch as the United States Government had not previously agreed to a meeting between the two.5

Although still reeling from the Guillaume affair, Honecker held a session of official talks with Schmidt which took on a ‘business-like and relaxed atmosphere’.6 Turning to grand strategy, the Chancellor noted that he, like his predecessor, was interested in continuing the policy which had been introduced in 1969. For his part, Honecker expressed interest in expanding trade, though Schmidt said it was ‘up to the GDR to work harder to increase its sales to the FRG market’. Pushing the subject, Honecker asked that West Germany do everything possible to expand its purchases from the GDR,